military take concrete action on its claims that it was willing to turn over a new leaf and undo the manipulation it enacted in 2018. Of course, back-channel contacts had long been going on between the PPP, the PML-N and other parties and the military once the latter realised that Pakistan was ungovernable without its support. Imran's style of governance—served with passionate speeches, contemptuous allegations against his rivals, even outright abuse—simply did not allow any kind of consensus to be built to take parliamentary democracy forward. But Nawaz Sharif's hardline stance vis-a-vis the military had also been an impediment to a compromise being worked out. Eventually, it seems, his more pragmatic brother, Shehbaz Sharif, and the PPP leader Asif Zardari and chairman Bilawal Bhutto-Zardari seem to have prevailed. They have taken a gamble, however, that the military will stick to its promises on non-interference in political matters.

Meanwhile, bereft of numbers in parliament and allies, Imran has decided to rouse and galvanise his support base. After banking on building support among the religious conservative segments of the electorate—he has long talked about building a replica of the state of Medina, has tapped into dangerous populist talk on blasphemy and positioned himself domestically as a champion against global Islamophobia—he has now also decided to plug into fiery anti-American rhetoric. Waving what he claimed was "a threatening letter from a foreign country" at a public rally—it was later accepted to be an internal cable of the Foreign Office—he has built a narrative that his ouster is part of an American conspiracy for regime change in Pakistan. He is hoping that, if nothing else, it will cast him as a heroic figure fighting against the forces of global imperialism.

How much that narrative helps him and his party in the election which will be held by the middle of next year at the latest—though it is likely it will take place sooner—remains to be seen. For now, Imran is banking on his demagoguery, desperately hoping people will forget the material failures of his government. He is also hoping that the opposition parties, united against him right now, will fracture once they have to go in for elections against each other, allowing him to pip them to the post in three-way—or more—electoral fights. He also hopes that his controversial laws allowing expatriate Pakistanis, including dual citizenship-holders, to vote from their adopted countries will tip the balance in the PTI's favour—there are over nine million Pakistanis abroad and an analysis has shown that they could impact a substantial number of constituencies.

But with most of his party's main financiers having deserted him and without the active backing of the military, it is difficult to see how Imran can put together the party structure needed to win an election in the immediate term, especially if the erstwhile opposition manages to undo some of the more controversial new voting laws. Imran's undeniable charisma and cult may attract a youthful demographic, especially those who despise the old mainstream parties, but winning elections requires organisation and money more than fusillades of populist rhetoric.

However, the opposition in Pakistan, too, is in a fix. On the one hand, there is the danger that elections will expose the rifts between its component parties, giving Imran's PTI a chance to squeeze through. On the other, the opposition, particularly the PML-N, fears that the longer things get stretched out before the

THE OPPOSITION FEARS A RIFT BETWEEN ITS COMPONENT PARTIES, GIVING PTI A CHANCE IN THE NEXT ELECTION. THE OPPOSITION ALSO DOES NOT YET HAVE A POLITICIAN WHO CAN MATCH IMRAN'S PERSONAL CHARISMA

THE KEY PLAYERS

PAKISTAN TEHREEK-E-INSAF (PTI)



IMRAN KHAN

Cricketer-turned-philanthropist-turned politician, Imran formed the PTI in 1996 and became prime minister of Pakistan in July 2018. Remains the party president of PTI and recently resigned as premier.

PAKISTAN MUSLIM LEAGUE-NAWAZ (PML-N)



NAWAZ SHARIF

Thrice PM of Pakistan. Disqualified from holding office by the Supreme Court after being convicted, sentenced to 7 years in jail. Currently in London for medical treatment. Still a powerful figure.



SHEHBAZ SHARIF

Younger brother of Nawaz and currently party president. He was leader of the opposition at the National Assembly. Was CM of Punjab thrice, seen as a good administrator. Seen as a potential PM.



MARYAM NAWAZ SHARIF

Daughter of Nawaz, currently vice president of PML-N. Disqualified from contesting polls because of a conviction in a corruption case. Is a good orator and crowd-puller.